



FROM THE CARDINAL'S TOOLKIT

Helping a Child Through Grief

Simple, honest words and small ways to help — no perfect words required.

Children grieve differently than adults — in bursts, through play, with questions that can catch you off guard. You do not need perfect words. Your steady, honest presence is what helps most.

Use clear, gentle words

- ☐ Say "died" rather than "passed away," "lost," or "sleeping" — soft phrases confuse young children.
- ☐ Keep it simple and true: "Grandpa's body stopped working, and it can't start again."
- ☐ Reassure them it isn't their fault, and that they are safe and loved.
- ☐ It's okay to say "I don't know." You can wonder together.

Expect grief to look different

- ☐ Children move in and out of grief — crying one minute, playing the next. That's healthy.
- ☐ Big feelings may show up as tummy aches, clinginess, anger, or trouble sleeping.
- ☐ They may ask the same questions again and again. Answer patiently; repetition is how they understand.
- ☐ Younger children may not grasp that death is permanent. Gently re-explain as needed.

Simple ways to help

- ☐ Keep routines steady — meals, bedtime, school. Predictability feels safe.
- ☐ Let them help remember: draw a picture, pick a photo, plant something, light a candle together.
- ☐ Offer feelings words: "You seem sad. Or maybe angry? Both are okay."
- ☐ Name your own feelings out loud, simply: "I miss her too. It's okay to cry."
- ☐ Read a picture book about loss together — stories give feelings a shape.

Questions children often ask

- ☐ "Will you die too?" — "I expect to be here a very long time, and other people love and care for you too."
- ☐ "Did I cause it?" — "No. Nothing you thought, said, or did made this happen."
- ☐ "Where are they now?" — Answer from your family's beliefs, simply and honestly.
- ☐ "Why are you sad?" — "Because I loved them. Missing people is part of love."

When to seek extra help

- ☐ If a child talks about wanting to die or join the person who died, seek help right away. In the US, call or text 988.
- ☐ If sleep, eating, school, or withdrawal stays badly disrupted for weeks, ask a pediatrician or child grief counselor.

- ☐ Look for child-specific grief support in your area; many communities have free programs.

You don't have to take their pain away to help. Staying close, telling the truth gently, and letting them feel — that is the whole job.

— The Cardinal's Toolkit

For more tools like this, The Cardinal's Toolkit has scripts and rituals for the whole family.